welcomed 12 of the 18 MLAs elected on a Congress ticket to further weaken his principal rival. Internal surveys suggest the 12 Congress defectors have "unsatisfactory" approval ratings. Rewarding them while denying tickets to party loyalists will only widen the schisms.

In another 15 segments or so, BRS legislators are facing a challenge from second-rung and next-generation leaders. Jagtial zilla parishad chairperson Dava Vasantha, for instance, is lobbying for the BRS ticket from the Jagtial seat held by party MLA M. Sanjay Kumar. The Kothagudem zilla parishad chairperson Koram Kanakaiah has already defected and is seeking a Congress ticket from the Yellandu seat. There is growing concern about these turf wars spreading to other constituencies. KCR has thus tasked both his children—son and cabinet minister K.T. Rama Rao, and daughter K. Kavitha—with curbing groupism through dialogue.

The BRS is especially wary of the Congress having the last laugh if the ruling party rebels decide to join it. "The Congress is our main rival," admits B. Vinod Kumar, a former BRS parliamentarian who is now the vice-chairman of the Telangana Planning Board. As far as the BJP is concerned, it's all "hype", he says, adding that the saffron party "does not have good, visible candidates in more than 10 seats". A few BRS ticket hopefuls also fear losing out to the Communist Party of India (CPI) and CPI (Marxist) candidates if KCR reaches a seat-sharing arrangement with the Left. The Communists are eyeing nearly 10 constituencies in the Khammam, Karimnagar and Nalgonda regions. For now, though, KCR has offered the CPI(M) just one seat. He has also proposed to provide the Communists two seats in the legislative council in lieu of their support.

In another eight constituencies, the BRS will be locked, like the last time, in a 'friendly match' with Asaduddin Owaisi's All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM). In effect, KCR faces uncertainty in more than half of the 119 constituencies. To counter this, he plans to poach Congress heavyweights, having started this pursuit with Bhongir district Congress chief K. Anil Kumar Reddy, who joined the BRS on July 24.

Even as he grapples with multiple dilemmas in allotting party tickets, KCR hopes to neutralise anti-incumbency by offering fresh sops, which his acolytes describe as the BRS supremo's 'Brahmastra'. These include



"KCR is sitting in Pragati Bhavan and muzzling the Opposition voice.... We will usher in a bulldozer government against corruption"

— G. KISHAN REDDY
President, Telangana BJP

the one-time Rs 1 lakh grant to poor families among the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), Muslims and Christians. Then, there are plans to raise the insurance cover under the Aarogyasri health scheme from Rs 2 lakh to Rs 5 lakh and introduce digital cards valid for 10 years. The Aasara pension for senior citizens and widows is also to be enhanced to Rs 3,016 from Rs 2,016. All these and more are to be announced along with the party manifesto that is to be unveiled with the first list of contestants later in August.

But not all are impressed. "KCR's propensity to distort facts enables him to announce new schemes though he fails to implement the existing ones," says former Congress irrigation minister Ponnala Lakshmaiah. He has reason to make such allegations. The BRS government spends about Rs 90,000 crore a year on various welfare schemes. But the state's outstanding liabilities, primarily through borrowings, have almost doubled in the past five years, forcing it to put the payouts on hold. The Dalit Bandhu scheme, for instance, which was launched in 2021 and provided Rs 10 lakh each for starting a business to 1,100 Scheduled Caste families in the Huzurabad assembly segment, was to be extended to 130,000 beneficiaries across the state. Four months later they are still waiting for the promised benefits.

"Anti-incumbency poses a big challenge to the BRS," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. "There is growing disenchantment among various groups, like the jobless youth and government employees, which KCR is taking lightly. It could prove detrimental to his party." He also points to governance-related issues, like the poor implementation of Dharani, the electronic revenue records portal, and mismanagement in the Telangana State Road Transport Corporation, which the Opposition could highlight to corner the KCR regime in the run-up to the assembly election. "The BRS thinks it can counter all this and scrape through by banking on its welfare schemes. But this trust seems to be misplaced," says Vageeshan.

In an attempt to bolster its strength, the BRS is to hold meetings with its OBC leaders to discuss ways to avoid a split in their vote bank. The OBCs together account for a little over 50 per cent of the state's population. "The polls are steadily becoming a bipolar contest between the BRS and the Congress. The moot question is whether with the Congress promising a caste census and [proportional] representation to them, will the OBCs overlook the BRS's welfare plank?" asks E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad's political science department. For the BRS to overcome this challenge, he says, it will have to expand its social profile in terms of the distribution of tickets. Time, it seems, is running out for KCR. ■